

IN CONTEXT

Weir at the Barbican Centre

In 2008, the BBC held a three-day festival of Weir's music at London's Barbican Centre, the largest multi-arts center in Europe. Weir's choral motet *Concrete*, inspired by the Barbican building itself, premiered at the festival.

Weir describes the piece as an archaeological exploration of the building, "burrowing through 2,500 years of historical rubble." Just as concrete is a mixture of different materials, so, too, does *Concrete* combine various elements: fragments of poems, diary entries, and other disjointed texts are mixed with the names of churches and river-gods to form the choral work.

Born to Scottish parents in Cambridge in 1954, Judith Weir spent her childhood near London. While at school, she played oboe with the National Youth Orchestra of Great Britain and studied composition under John Tavener. Her interest in arrangement emerged in these early years, when she would think up tunes that she and her friends could play together in different instrumental combinations—writing music evolved gradually from this.

Early years

At the University of Cambridge she was tutored by the composer Robin Holloway. Her influences were wide-ranging and included Monteverdi, Mozart, Wagner, and Verdi, whose mastery of form is as enthralling as their storytelling and sheer musical brilliance.

Weir graduated from Cambridge in 1976. Her entry into opera